

want 20 years from now. Ask your children if they will eventually want that set of brandy glasses, and check back every couple of years to see if they are still interested. I am the not-so-proud owner of a monstrous set of big, fake plastic grapes glued to a piece of driftwood that I *loved* as a child. They belonged to my grandmother, and I used to think they were magical. Now, I can't think of anything to do with them, short of launching them into the ocean using a homemade trebuchet.

BUT THIS IS A POTENTIAL HEIRLOOM!

So you may think. If you believe you are the owner of an object of heirloom quality, get it appraised and store it properly. Many of the things that you consider heirloom quality might not be, although an heirloom doesn't necessarily have to have monetary value. Also, you might want to consider the possibility that you may have a potential heirloom that nobody wants. My grandmother left me a gigantic, gaudy 1970s gold ring with a giant amethyst in the middle, knobs of twisted gold, and lots of little diamonds around the sides. I appreciated the value of the gift,

if not the aesthetic, and so I had a jeweler melt it down and make three different pieces of classical, timeless jewelry out of it. That way, one ugly item became three different pieces of jewelry that I can hand down to my children.

IT'LL BE WORTH SO MUCH MONEY SOMEDAY!

This might be true. But although collections can be fun to keep, if your entire house is consumed by boxed action figures à la *The 40-Year-Old Virgin*, you may want to consider paring down. If collectibles are getting in the way of your everyday living, selling some of them off now will save you years of annoyance, which is worth a bit of money. You can invest that money and watch it grow, and it will grow faster than the value of the baseball card / action figure / porcelain doll, without a doubt.

Once you've broken down the mental wall of letting go of junk, here are some tactics to actually help you sort through it.

1. Start small, with one closet or one corner of a room.

Set realistic goals and pace yourself. Try using an egg timer to set